

THE ANVIL

a ten-minute fiction adventure

CAST

MILA — the one who believes the story
REN — the one who knows it's only water
HALE — the old one, who climbed here once before
PIP — the youngest, who asks everything

MILA Look at it. The whole sky, doing that, all morning, and nobody down there ever looks up.
PIP *I'm* looking up. There — the big fat one. It's a bear. No — a bear riding a bicycle.
MILA Bears don't ride bicycles, Pip.
PIP That one does. It's pedaling. ...Okay, now it's a jellyfish.
REN It's a cumulus cloud. Warm air rises off the valley, the water in it cools, it condenses. It's not a bear, and it's not pedaling anything.
PIP You're not pedaling anything either, and I still like you.
MILA Save your breath, both of you. We've a mountain to climb before dark.
REN *We* have a mountain. *You* have a fairy tale.
MILA My grandmother climbed the Anvil when she was nineteen.
REN Your grandmother *told* you she climbed the Anvil.
MILA She told me what she saw at the top. Inside the cloud. She said the Anvil wears a cloud like a hat, every day of the year, sun or storm — and if you climb all the way up into it, it shows you where the clouds have gone. Everyone who's gone.
REN And you believe that.
MILA I'm going up to find out. That's a different thing from believing.
HALE It's a full day's climb. Longer if the weather turns. And on the Anvil, the weather always turns.
PIP You've been up here! Hale — you never said.
HALE Once. A long time ago. I didn't reach the top.
PIP Why not?
HALE Because the mountain was wearing a different hat that day. — Come on. The light's good now. It won't stay good.

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PIP It's steeper up here. And colder. And there's less of everything — less trees, less birds.
MILA That's how you know it's working. Turn around — you can see the whole valley now.
PIP We're higher than that bear-cloud! We're looking *down* on it, Ren! You can look down on a cloud!
REN ...Yeah. Yeah, you can.
MILA Not so certain now, are you.
REN I know exactly what it is. I just didn't know it would look like *that* from above. Like a field. Like a person could walk right out onto it.
PIP Can we?
REN No. You'd drop straight through it and fall a very long way and die.
PIP You are so fun.
HALE Eyes up. See that grey wall, building over the far ridge? That's not afternoon shade. That's water. A great deal of it, coming this way.
MILA How long do we have?
HALE Before the sun's gone — an hour. Before that reaches us — less.
REN Then we should think about turning back. We come again tomorrow, in better—
MILA There is no tomorrow. The story says the cloud opens once for each climber. One hat. One question. You turn back now, you never get another.
REN That's not weather, Mila, that's a superstition you learned as a kid.
MILA Then wait here for me. But I am not going back down without standing inside it.
HALE Nobody splits up on the Anvil. Nobody. — That's the one rule I carried back down with me.
PIP What happened up here, Hale? The first time. The true version.

HALE ...I climbed it with my brother. We hit the weather right about where we're standing now. He wanted to push on. I wanted to turn back. We argued. And then the cloud came down over us, and I couldn't find him in it. I called and called. I searched for two days. The mountain kept him.

MILA Hale. I'm — I didn't know.

HALE So. We don't split up. And we don't stand here talking while that thing decides to arrive. If we're going up, we go together, and we go now.

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PIP It's here — it's here! I can't — the rain's coming sideways!

REN Get down! Behind the rock — Pip, the rock, *now!*

MILA Hale, I've lost the path — I can't see the path!

HALE There is no path in this. There's only up. Hand on the shoulder of the one in front of you. Pip — you've got my coat. Do not let go of my coat.

PIP I've got it! I've got it, I've got it—

REN This is insane, this is *exactly* how people die on mountains, this precise—

MILA Then help me get us through it!

REN I am *trying*—

HALE Listen to me. All of you. The storm is not hunting us. It doesn't know we exist. It's only water, finding its way down — the same as we're finding our way up. Don't fight it. Move with it. Move.

PIP It's so loud, I can't hear you—

MILA Then keep talking to me, Pip. Keep talking so I know where you are.

PIP I'm here! I'm freezing and I'm scared and I'm *here!*

MILA Good. Stay right here. Stay with me.

HALE ...Wait. Wait — do you feel that? The wind's dropping.

REN The rain's — it's easing. It's easing off.

PIP The sky's going pink! Over there — look — it's turning *pink!*

HALE That's the storm passing beneath us. We climbed up through the roof of it. — We climbed clean through the top of the storm.

MILA And it let us go.

HALE ...This time. This time it let us go.

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PIP Is that— is that *it*? At the very top? The white?

MILA That's the cloud. That's the hat. We made it — we actually made it—

REN It's full night now. Stars everywhere. Everywhere except right there, sitting on the peak. Just... a patch of white, with the stars gone out behind it.

HALE That's as far as I ever came. Right to the edge of it. — Go on. I'll wait here. This one isn't mine.

MILA Come with us, Hale.

HALE No. I got my answer years ago. I've only been carrying it since. Go and get yours.

PIP What's it like inside? I can't see — Mila? Mila, where are you? You were right — I can't even see my own hands!

MILA I'm here. It's all white. It's so quiet in here. Pip? Ren? Somebody say something so I know—

REN I'm here. ...It's water. It is — I can feel it on my face, it's only water — but I keep thinking I can hear something. That's not — clouds don't make a sound.

PIP I hear it too. It sounds like a lot of people, a long way off. Like a whole town, all talking at once, but too far away to catch the words.

MILA ...Gran?

REN Mila?

MILA I heard her. Ren — I heard her voice. She said my name. She said— ... Or the wind did. I can't tell. I can't tell if it was her, or if it was only the—

REN ...I can't tell either. And I'm the one who's meant to know.

PIP Does it matter?

MILA What?

PIP Whether it was really her. You heard your gran. You'll *always* have heard your gran — up here, in the white. That's real now, isn't it? It's already happened. Nobody can take it back out of you.

MILA ...No. No, they can't. It already happened.

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REN It's getting light. Look — the sun's coming up *underneath* us.

PIP And the cloud — Mila, the cloud's *leaving!* The hat's lifting right off the mountain!

MILA It's only moving on. That's what they do. Down the valley, out over the sea, back up again as rain. It'll come back. Maybe not this exact one. But a cloud will always come back.

HALE You all came back. — First time I've ever stood here and watched this mountain give somebody back.

PIP Do you think it'll remember us? The cloud?

HALE The cloud won't. But we'll remember the cloud. — Maybe that's the same thing, in the end. Maybe we're only the part of the mountain that gets to remember.

MILA Come on. Let's go down while the light holds.

PIP Can we come back? Tomorrow?

MILA It'll be a different mountain tomorrow. Different hat. Different sky.

PIP ...But so will we.

MILA But so will we.

END.